The pain had actually increased in the interim and I was now struggling to walk properly. On our way to the hospital I asked Andrew not to tell me about the results of the X-ray, for no matter what, I wanted to play in the final. Soon after the X-ray, Andrew, looking somewhat helpless, just said to me, ‘You are a crazy man.’

Before the game it was decided that Andrew would strap the toe bent down to prevent any movement and I took the field against the West Indies in considerable physical discomfort. I had been in terrific touch throughout the tournament and the thinking was that my batting was more important for the team than my fielding and bowling. Personally, I felt I would be able to make it through the game, as it happened to be the final match. After all that effort, however, I proceeded to get out for a duck and we lost the match. It turned out I had damaged my sesamoid bone, which is the bone at the connection of the big toe and the first metatarsal.

After returning to India I was prescribed total rest, but after two months I still wasn’t happy with the way the recovery was going. I could barely walk without discomfort. In desperation I saw a specialist, who advised me to have surgery. We even fixed a tentative date, but that’s when Anjali advised me to seek a second opinion. She felt that surgery should always be the last resort and we had to be sure there was no other way to get the injury treated.

We went to the Bombay hospital and saw one of the most senior doctors around, Dr Dholakia. He showed me a big fat book on sesamoid bones and informed me that the author of the book, who was the world expert on sesamoid injuries, wasn’t a hundred per cent certain that surgery was the best way to treat them. He went on to say that I shouldn’t allow anyone to touch my toe, as it might be counterproductive. There was the possibility of permanent damage, which might bring my career to an end, and that was a scary thought. On the very same day Dr Dholakia started looking into where I could go to get my toe examined by a specialist.

Eventually I found myself at the Rosebank Clinic in Johannesburg, where Dr Mark Ferguson, who had worked with a lot of sportsmen, advised me to try out a few insoles. Over a week in South Africa I went from walking for fifteen minutes to close to an hour. Back in Mumbai I continued with the routine, building up from jogging to running. Running in cricket shoes was a bit of a problem because of the spikes, so